Page 1 - The Lighthouse Keeper

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Every evening he climbed the one hundred and twelve steps with a can of oil in each hand, counting them under his breath as his father had taught him. At the top the lamp waited, patient and enormous, a great cut-glass eye that looked out over the grey water.

On the night this story begins the wind came from the north-east, and it brought with it a thin cold rain that rattled on the gallery like handfuls of thrown gravel. Tobias trimmed the wick, wound the clockwork, and settled to his watch.

Far below, the sea heaved itself against the rocks and fell back again, over and over, with the slow patience of something that has all the time in the world.

Page 2 - A Stranger on the Shore

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It was past midnight when Tobias saw the figure on the shingle. At first he took it for a trick of the rain, a bundle of weed or a fallen spar, but the shape moved, and lifted one arm, and he understood that someone was alive down there.

He went down faster than he had gone in twenty years, a lantern swinging in his fist and the cold biting at his lungs. The stranger was a young woman wrapped in a sodden coat, and she was shivering so hard that she could not speak.

He carried her to the cottage at the foot of the tower and set her by the stove. When at last she could talk, she told him that her name was Imogen Hale, that her small boat had been driven onto the rocks, and that she had been rowing toward the light for three hours.

Page 3 - What the Tide Brought

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Tobias said nothing, but he stood a little straighter, and went back up the stairs to his lamp with something warm lodged in his chest.

By morning the storm had blown itself out, and the sea lay flat and silver under a washed sky. Imogen walked the beach with a borrowed pair of boots, gathering what the tide had delivered: planks, rope, a single oar, and a brass-bound chest that was far too heavy to lift.

Page 4 - Letters in Blue Ribbon

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Together they dragged it above the high-water line. The lock had rusted through, and a few blows with a hammer broke it open. Inside, wrapped in oilcloth, lay a bundle of letters tied with blue ribbon and a small, battered compass.

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Page 5 - The Long Way Home

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When the supply boat came on Friday, Imogen went back with it to the mainland, carrying the letters and the compass in her coat. She left behind her address, written in a careful hand, and a promise to return in the spring.

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He waved back. It seemed to him then that the light had finished one long errand and begun another.

Imogen stayed that summer, and the summer after. She learned to trim the wick and wind the clockwork, and to read the weather in the colour of the evening sky. She had a gift for it, Tobias said, the same gift her grandfather must have had.

Page 8 - A Stranger on the Shore

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In time the Trinity House inspectors came, in their polished boots and serious hats, and were surprised to find two keepers where there had been one. They inspected the brass and the glass and the logbook, and pronounced everything in excellent order.

On the evening they left, Tobias and Imogen climbed the tower together and watched the lamp kindle. The beam swept out across the water, steady and unhurried, and far off a ship's lantern answered it.

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Page 9 - What the Tide Brought

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